



SCREECH OWL FLIES FREE -- This cute little owl was released off Davidson-Concord Road Jan. 28 after a year and a half of rehabilitation. Carolina Raptor Center volunteer Debbie Whitt (pictured holding the owl) cared for the bird after he ran into a car while flying over Jetton Road in 1991. (Photo by Gina Piccalo)

Rescued Screech Owl Returned To Forest

by Gina Piccalo

has helped improve the raptor

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The North Mecklenburg forests reclaimed one of their own last week. After more than a year of rehabilitation at the Carolina Raptor Center, a screech owl was set free.

"It's like a part of you goes up with him," said two-year Carolina Raptor Center volunteer Debbie Whitt. "This is what it's all about."

In November 1991, DeDe Pucella and her sons Brian and Peter were driving down Jetton Road when the owl hit the windshield of their van.

"It looked like a towel flew right out in front of us," said 15-year old, Brian.

The owl fell to the ground, too stunned to move. Brian wrapped him in a blanket and took him home. The next day the Pucellas brought their find to the North Mecklenburg Animal Hospital where the veterinarian recommended they take the owl to the raptor center.

"If they hadn't turned around and stopped, (the owl) would have died," said Whitt.

Despite Whitt's care, the unnamed screech owl wasn't a very good patient. In an attempt to tear off his bandages he broke his tail and wing feathers. His release was delayed until his feathers grew back or molted. Since birds of prey, or raptors, molt only once a year, Jan. 28 was set as the owl's date with freedom.

"We hope we don't see him again," said Whitt of the owl. The year and a half old screech owl was tagged during his treatment so if ever found again, he will be identifiable.

Since rescuing the owl, Brian

has helped improve the raptor center. As part of his Eagle Scout project, he built benches on the center's grounds.

The Pucella's experience is a very common occurrence, said Whitt. She estimates one injured or orphaned bird is brought to the Raptor Center each day. As North Mecklenburg's population increases, so do the dangers against area wildlife. Most owl injuries are caused by vehicles, according to Whitt.

"People think when they throw a piece of food out in the road it just rots," she said. "But, no, the mice go after it and then the owls go after the mice."

To help preserve wildlife Whitt recommends area residents "make their backyard a nice habitat for wildlife." This can be done by choosing certain shrubs and trees to decorate their lawns or building owl boxes in trees. For more information on how you can help keep North Mecklenburg an attractive home for wildlife call the Carolina Raptor Center at 875-6521.